

Architect Spotlight: Frank Gehry

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



In 1969, a Canadian-born artist made a chair out of pieces of corrugated cardboard glued together. This launched a phenomenon known as the Easy Edges collection, and also began the career of one of the most widely known architects of the 20th century, Frank Gehry.

Early Life

Born as Frank Owen Goldberg in Toronto, Canada, to a Polish and Jewish family in 1929, young Frank took to creativity almost instantly. Using found items around his grandfather's hardware store, Frank enjoyed creating small model homes with unconventional materials. A common theme in Gehry's later works.

College

In 1949, Gehry moved to Los Angeles to attend the University of Southern California to study in the School of Architecture. This was also when Gehry changed his surname to the one now commonly known. After achieving his undergrad, Gehry moved east to Massachusetts in 1956. He enrolled at the Harvard Graduate School of Design but dropped out before graduating.

Career

Shortly after dropping out of Harvard, Gehry returned to Southern California. He began creating furniture as part of his Easy Edges collection. The money he earned from his intriguing furniture designs allowed him to remodel his Santa Monica home. The resulting angular corrugated steel fencing and large odd-shaped windows grabbed the attention of the Southern California architecture community.

An advertisement for "SOLAR ME HOME". At the top, it says "Electricity bill too high?" in white text on a blue background. Below that, "GO SOLAR" is written in large, bold, yellow letters. Underneath, "Find Installers!" is written in a script font with a curved arrow pointing to the left. A white rounded rectangle contains the text "Your Zip Code" and a green circular button with the word "GO" in white. The bottom half of the ad shows a smiling family (a man, a woman, and two children) in front of a house with solar panels on the roof. The "SOLAR ME HOME" logo is in the top right corner.

(<https://solarmehome.com/?cid=28806>)

An advertisement for "pursuemortgage". The background is a dark blue silhouette of a tree on the left and a house on the right. In the center, a family (a man, a woman, and a child) is walking. The text "pursuemortgage" is written in white, with "pursue" in a smaller font and "mortgage" in a larger, bolder font. Below that, "Thinking About Refinancing?" is written in white. At the bottom, a yellow button with the text "Find Lenders Now" is shown.

(<https://pursuemortgage.com/?cid=28806>)

Gehry's home became a statement in Deconstructionist style, which would later define his signature works. Essentially, Gehry intentionally broke from the long held conventional structural aesthetic, which boldly supplanted him in his own class of architect. The architectural community was ready for such a wildly disparate structural form and accepted Gehry's avant-garde architectural approach wholesale.

Notable Works

Gehry Residence



By IK's World Trip [CC BY 2.0 (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0>)], via Wikimedia Commons

Gehry's personal renovation and remodel of his own home launched his architectural career. The once-furniture designer used corrugated steel, chain link fencing and angular windows to create a bold architectural statement. When notable architects took notice, Gehry gained a foothold in the often contentious world of high profile architecture.

Art Gallery of Ontario

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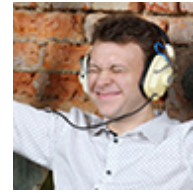
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The Art Gallery of Ontario (AGO) holds a special place in Gehry's heart. The museum concedes (<http://bit.ly/1D6u1BX>) that it "marks the very place where he made the initial connection between art and architecture." Gehry, being Toronto-born, returned to the gallery to give it a facelift. Resident New York Times architecture critic Nicolai Ouroussoff notes (<http://nyti.ms/1DntBI1>), "This may be one of Mr. Gehry's most gentle and self-possessed designs."



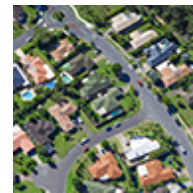
(<http://homeliving101.com/lifestyle/get-off-my-lawn-epic-neighbor-feuds-and-how-to-avoid-them/>)

We all dream of finding the perfect home. We obsess over the number of bedrooms, being close to good



(<http://homeliving101.com/hl-trends/absolutely-obsolete/>)

Few things are permanent in this disposable culture of ours. But it's still hard to believe how quickly to-



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There is no more potent image of American prosperity than a sprawling tree-lined street filled with large single-family homes. In a word: suburbia - born...

Walt Disney Concert Hall



MR. INTERIOR (<http://www.shutterstock.com/gallery-1167089p1.html?cr=00&pl=edit-00>) / Shutterstock.com
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Vying the title of the symbol of Los Angeles against the Hollywood sign, Gehry's triumphant design for the Walt Disney Concert Hall left many mouths agape when it was finished in 2003 (<http://bit.ly/1zp1bgi>). Although the metallic titanium sheen was by design, it was quickly sanded down to a brilliant matte finish due to the Los Angeles residents complaining about the distracting reflections of the sun bouncing off the mirror-like façade.

Spruce Street Tower



Daniel M. Silva (<http://www.shutterstock.com/gallery-571993p1.html?cr=00&pl=edit-00>) / Shutterstock.com
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Gehry's first skyscraper proves his signature lines can manage an 870-foot, 76-story (<http://bit.ly/16ABSLy>) structure. Ouroussoff [adds](http://nyti.ms/16ABXz6) (<http://nyti.ms/16ABXz6>), "In daylight the furrowed surfaces of the facades look as if they've been etched by rivulets of water, an effect that is all the more dramatic next to the clunky 1980s glass towers just to the south."

Guggenheim Museum Bilbao



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Rivaling the Walt Disney Concert Hall in profile and notoriety is Gehry's Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao, Spain. Opened in 1997, and sharing a similar design to Disney's Concert Hall, the Guggenheim Museum Bilbao has been "hailed as the most important structure of its time," as [noted](http://bit.ly/1DnvX9H) (<http://bit.ly/1DnvX9H>) by the official Guggenheim website. Using a steel frame and titanium siding, the Guggenheim Museum Bilbao has maintained its reflective luster that was sadly short lived on the Walt Disney Concert Hall.

Takeaway

Few architects have managed such a lengthy career in the spotlight with a clearly identifiable style. Gehry's designs are distinctly his own and many who know nothing about architecture can often spot Gehry's work. This makes him more than just an effective architect. It makes him a contemporary artist who chooses habitable structures as his canvas.

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